



HIGH LIFE

The very tall emergent trees attract colorful birds such as these toucans. Predators, including the South American harpy eagle, prey on the monkeys and sloths that live in the main canopy—the most populated layer. Around the world, this layer is also the home of parrots, birds-of-paradise, gibbons, fruit bats, lizards, and tree snakes. The air rings with the calls of birds and tree frogs.

TREETOP NURSERIES

In the forests of Central and South America, tiny poison-dart frogs are protected from predators by their highly toxic skin. Their vivid colors warn enemies to leave them alone. Some raise their tadpoles in the tiny pools that form in plants growing at the tops of trees, and feed each tadpole on spare, unfertilized eggs.



▲ BREEDING POOL

This poison-dart frog has claimed a pool in a bromeliad plant, high above the forest floor.

INSECT HEAVEN

Tropical rainforests are alive with insects such as butterflies and moths, bees, wasps, termites, and an astonishing variety of beetles—most of them still not scientifically described. In one study, scientists discovered 600 new beetle species living on just one type of rainforest tree.



▲ FOREST BEAUTY

Flowers open all year round in tropical rainforests, making life easy for nectar-feeding butterflies.

THE FOREST FLOOR

In all tropical forests, the floor is the home of larger animals, including tapirs, peccaries, forest elephants, gorillas, and spectacular jungle pheasants. Predators such as big cats, snakes, giant spiders, and army ants prowl through the undergrowth or lie in ambush for victims.

► HUNGRY HUNTER

A jaguar scents prey in the tropical forest of Amazonia. This beautifully marked cat is the South American equivalent of the leopard.

